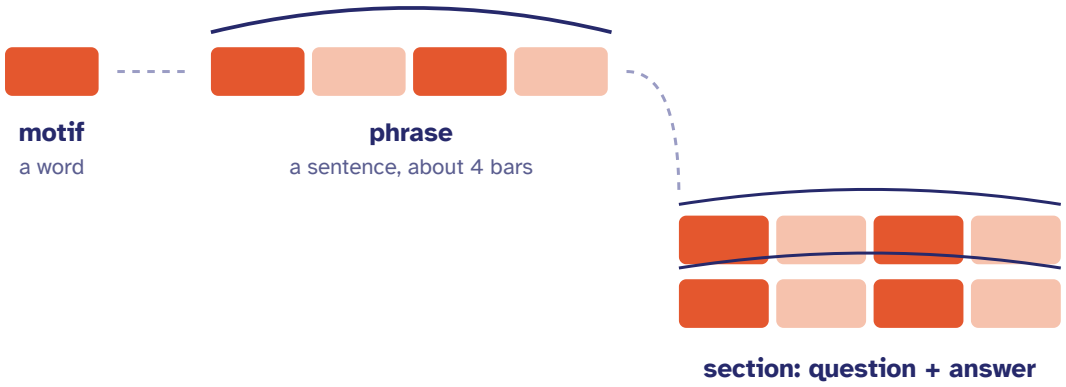
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1

Motifs and phrases

A tune is built like a story. A tiny idea, the **motif**, grows into a **phrase**, a musical sentence; two phrases make a question and its answer. Spot the building blocks and a page of notes turns into a few ideas.
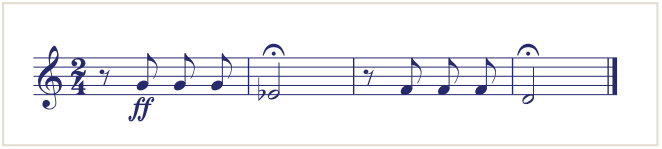
THE SECRET

A motif is a word, a phrase a sentence: a question ends away from home, an answer comes home.
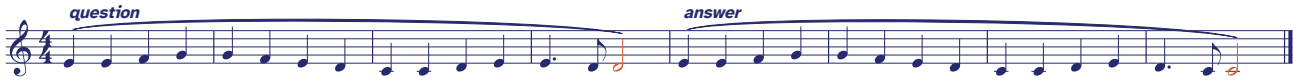


Words, sentences, paragraphs

A motif



Four notes, short-short-short-long: Beethoven builds the whole first movement of his Fifth Symphony from them. A motif is short (2 to 6 notes) and easy to recognise: its **rhythm** and its **shape** come back again and again.

Phrases: question and answer



Ode to Joy: two 4-bar phrases. The first ends on D, away from home (a question); the second comes home to C (an answer).
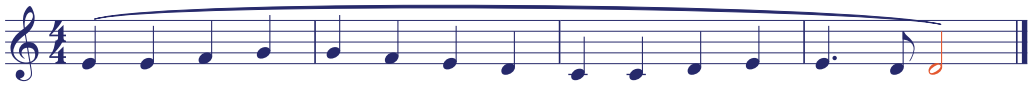
THE RULE

Most phrases are 4 bars long. A question phrase ends away from the key note; the answer comes home to it.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Question or answer?
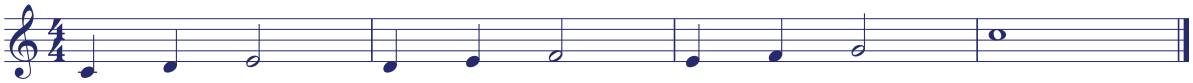


1. **The key is C major.** What is the home note?
2. **The last note** of this phrase is…?
3. **Is it home?**

It ends on D, not C: a **question**. The answer phrase that follows ends on C.

EXAMPLE 2

Find the motif



1. **Look at bar 1:** what shape and rhythm?
2. **Bars 2 and 3:** the same shape?
3. **Where** does each start?

Step, step, long: three notes. It comes **three times**, each a step higher.

GAME
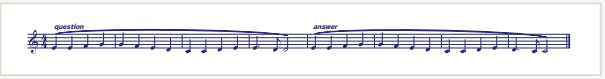
How many phrases?

1	2	3
8 bars	12 bars	16 bars

Each phrase is 4 bars long. How many phrases in a tune of…

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 four.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
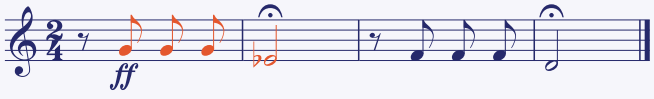


Sing a question, then an answer.

Sing the question and stop on the D: it hangs in the air. Now sing the answer and land on C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Symphony No. 5



"Da-da-da-**DUM**": the most famous motif ever written. Listen to the first minute and count how many times it comes back.

Try it. Tap the rhythm on the lid, then sing it a step lower.

TRAP

× Playing every note the same: each phrase has one high point to grow towards.

SEE ALSO

Slurs and phrases p. 76 · Cadences p. 135

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Phrases